Wellington, which definitely helped our chances. I was given the ball a little before lunch on day five and was pleased to get the crucial wicket of Brendon McCullum, caught at slip for 6. Then I could tell that James Franklin, the last recognized batsman, wasn't picking my googlies and was trying to sweep every ball to negate the overspin. I asked Dhoni to take the fielder away from point and place two fielders at short square leg. This would stop Franklin from playing the sweep shot and would force him to cut. The plan worked and I had Franklin lbw soon after making the field change.

We would have won the match if Ishant had held on to a chance from Iain O'Brien in the deep. The spilled catch allowed New Zealand a lifeline before the heavens opened after lunch, bringing a premature end to the match. Close to two sessions of play were lost to rain and we missed out on a golden opportunity.

An incident from this New Zealand series gives an idea of how much difference local conditions can make to a team's chances. It happened at Christchurch during the ODI series when Zaheer was bowling. He had bowled a good-length ball and the batsman's attempted front-foot slog over midwicket turned into a top edge. Zaheer screamed out 'MINE!' and carefully positioned himself for the catch. To his dismay, the wind got hold of the ball and it landed at least fifteen feet away. Later we all joked with him, saying, 'So the catch was *yours*, was it, Zak?'

Aiming for the top

Our rise up the ICC Test rankings had started in England back in 2007. Now, after the successful series in New Zealand, we had the opportunity to take the number-one position if we beat Sri Lanka at home in November–December 2009.

The series against Sri Lanka was also special for personal reasons, because I notched up twenty years in international cricket in November 2009. I celebrated the occasion by speaking to the media for more than seven hours, giving close to fifty one-on-one interviews. So much for people saying I did not talk to the media enough! Looking back at how uncomfortable I was at my first press conference in 1990, I had indeed come a long way.

I remember being confronted with a camera for the first time as an awkward teenager. In my early TV advertisements, I was not what you